

GETTING STARTED

Amigurumi for Beginners: Your First Stuffed Toy

What makes amigurumi different from other crochet, the tools you actually need, and how to avoid the mistakes that trip up most first attempts.

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Amigurumi — the Japanese craft of crocheting small stuffed toys and characters — looks intimidating because finished pieces are so detailed. In practice, it's built from the same two stitches most beginners already know: chain and single crochet. What makes it feel different is the technique, not the skill level.

How amigurumi differs from other crochet

If you've worked through our [guide to reading a pattern](#), most amigurumi instructions will already look familiar — abbreviations and stitch counts work the same way.

Three things are different:

- **Continuous rounds, not joined.** Instead of joining each round with a slip stitch, you work in a spiral, using a stitch marker to track where each round starts.
- **A smaller hook than the yarn label suggests.** This tightens your stitches so stuffing doesn't peek through — see the hook size question in our FAQ below for exact sizing.

- **Shaping through increases and decreases.** Rounds don't stay a constant stitch count the way a flat square does; they grow and shrink to form heads, bodies, and limbs.

What you actually need to start

Amigurumi patterns can list a long supply chart, but your first project only needs four things:

- **A smaller hook** than you'd normally use with your yarn — see our [hook buying guide](#) if you don't have one yet in the 2.5–3.5mm range.
- **Worsted-weight cotton or acrylic yarn** in a light colour, so you can see your stitches while you're still learning the spiral technique.
- **Stuffing** — polyester fiberfill, not cotton balls or fabric scraps, which clump and go lumpy.
- **Safety eyes**, for anything that needs a face and might be handled by a child.

The mistake that ruins most first attempts

Loose stitches are the single biggest reason a first amigurumi looks messy rather than cute. If your stitches are loose enough to see stuffing through the fabric, drop to a smaller hook before starting your next project — it's a far easier fix than trying to crochet tighter by hand.

Frequently asked questions

What is amigurumi in simple terms?

Amigurumi is the Japanese craft of crocheting small stuffed toys, usually worked in the round with single crochet to create a tight, dense fabric that holds stuffing without gaps.

What hook size is best for amigurumi?

Most amigurumi patterns use a hook one or two sizes smaller than the yarn label recommends, typically 2.5mm to 3.5mm for standard worsted-weight yarn. The smaller hook keeps stitches tight enough to hide stuffing.

Do I need safety eyes for amigurumi, or can I use buttons?

Safety eyes are strongly recommended for anything a child might handle, since they lock in place and resist pulling out. Buttons or embroidered eyes are fine for toys made purely for display or adult collectors.

Written by Emily Hartwell

Emily has been crocheting for over a decade, ever since her grandmother taught her the basics one summer. She started CrochetGuides to write the clear, honest, beginner-friendly instructions she wishes she'd had when she was learning — the ones that actually work the first time.